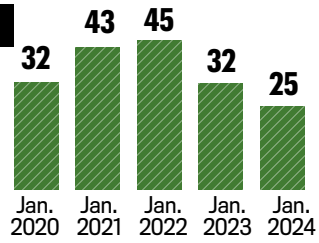
FOREX RESERVES

From a high in 2022, Bangladesh's foreign exchange reserves have gradually fallen

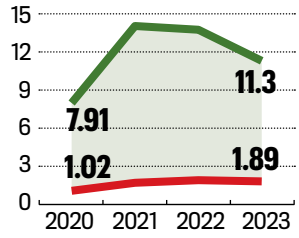
Forex reserves (in $ bn)



TRADE

Bilateral trade has usually seen a large trade deficit in favour of India

Import from India ($ bn)
Export to India ($ bn)



TOP INDIAN EXPORTS TO BANGLADESH

- Mineral fuels, oils, distillation products — $2.19 bn
- Cotton — $2.18 bn
- Residues, wastes of food industry, animal fodder — $733 mn
- Vehicles — $593.9 mn
- Machinery, nuclear reactors, boilers — $552.4 mn
- Edible vegetables — $464.3 mn

TOP INDIAN IMPORTS FROM BANGLADESH

- Apparel, not knit — $425.3 mn
- Apparel, knit — $236.6 mn
- Vegetable textile fibres — $218.3 mn
- Aircraft — $171.8 mn

NEW DELHI NEEDS TO NEGOTIATE THE MINEFIELD OF COMPETING INTERESTS DEFTLY TO ENSURE ITS TIES WITH DHAKA STAY STRONG, ITS CORE INTERESTS SECURE, AND HINDUS PROTECTED

subscribe to the 'Islam'" of Jamaat or, for that matter, Islamist or secularist ideologies. He went on to explain, "I have a vision for a civilisationally transformed state in this region and society based on ideals of Compassion and Responsibility. Individual and collective aspirations of the oppressed multitude will find ways to be translated into state policies."

Reassurance that Bangladesh will not radically alter its constitutional ethos comes from Ali Riaz, the noted political scientist and recently appointed head of Bangladesh's Constitutional Reform Commission. Riaz has been candid about the importance of maintaining Bangladesh's pluralistic and inclusive identity amidst fears of rising Islamisation. "It is in the best interests of Bangladesh that it remains pluralistic and inclusive," Riaz asserted. "Our recommendation will be that pluralism is the foundation of the country and that should remain undisturbed. Everyone in the country, irrespective of any differences, must enjoy equal opportunities." It remains to be seen if his views gain acceptance and are ratified by the ruling dispensation.

Meanwhile, mainstream political parties, especially the BNP, are keen that elections are held soon and not a year later, as Yunus and the student leaders have indicated. The BNP is fast occupying the vacuum left by the disintegration of the Awami League and has already taken over the trade unions and similar bodies at local levels. Its acting chairperson, Tarique Rahman, the 59-year-old son of former president Ziaur Rahman and former prime minister Khaleda Zia, is set to make a comeback to Dhaka sometime in January, after years of exile in London. The slew of cases against him have been lifted, the latest being on December 10, paving the way for his return. The BNP is pushing Yunus to hold an election within the next six months. Says Salahuddin Ahmed, a key BNP leader, "We don't think the interim government can or should delay the polls any further than May. The reforms that the country needs can only be executed by a democratically elected government." The Jamaat, though, would like polls to be held later to get enough time to rebuild the party. However, both BNP and Jamaat will have to contend with the ambitions of student leaders like Alam who are keen on forming their own political grouping to contest elections.

Back in Dhaka, wall art and graffiti remain the only reminders of the uprising in which 2,000 people are claimed to have been killed. Life has resumed in the bustling downtown area of Purana Paltan crossing, the posh neighbourhoods of Gulshan and Dhanmondi and the pretty cafes on the banks of the humongous Hatirjheel lake. The Ganabhaban, the party office of Awami League, wears a deserted look. Mujibur Rahman, once hailed as the father of the nation, has been dislodged from that lofty perch. All that is left of his giant statue that the protesters toppled in August are his two feet. The impressive Jatiyo Sangsad Bhaban or Parliament, once a hive of activity, seems evidently in disuse. Which party occupies these premises in the coming year will determine the course ahead for the country. It will be a new Bangladesh, and India will have to find new ways to deal with it. ■